

Kwile' (lesson five)

Outer subject prefixes to verbs

Two of the remaining subjects, 'we' and 'they', are marked by *outer subject* prefixes, in contrast to 'I', 'we (du.)', 'you (sg.)' and 'you (pl.)', which are marked by the *inner subject* prefixes discussed in lessons 3 and 4. The positional difference between inner and outer subjects can be seen in the following imperfective paradigm¹ for the verb 'cough', which consists of the elements **d-l-kwis**.² The inner subject prefixes occur to the right of **d-** and the outer subject prefixes occur to the left of **d-**:

digilkwis	'I'm coughing'
dilkwis	'cough, you're coughing'
diwhlhkwis	'cough (you pl.), you (pl.) are coughing'
didilkwis	'we (du.) are coughing'
ts'idilkwis	'we're coughing'
hidilkwis	'they're coughing'

The 7th member of this paradigm is the third person singular subject form:

dilkwis	'he/she is coughing'
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Remember that a verb which has neither inner nor outer subject prefix is simply interpreted as having 'he/she/it' as subject.

'We' (First person plural, 1pl subject)

The first person plural subject prefix has two shapes, **ts'-** and **z-**.

The form **z-** is used when the preceding sound is a vowel and the following sounds are a sequence of consonant plus vowel:

deztadilh	'we will go inside'
dezniindil	'we went inside'

However, when the following consonant is **w** or **y**, the form **ts'-** rather than **z-** of the 1pl subject prefix tends to be preferred:

¹a paradigm is a set of related things, in our case, related words.

²Note that **d-l-kwis** is not a pronounceable word like 'cough'. In Witsuwit'en you must add one of the time-marking prefixes (such as **i-** imperfective) to make this into a word.

nets' iwi'ayh	'we're doing research, finding things out'
k'ë nets' iwi'tayh	'we're blaming ourselves'
nc' its' iwilhyekh	'we're punishing you'
wets' iyilh'its	'we haven't sneezed, aren't sneezing'
bil ats' iyinle	'we took them away from him/her'

The form **ts'**- is used in all other contexts:

ts' itsagh	'we're crying'
ts' ilhk'agh	'we're fat'
ts' inilgit	'we're afraid'
ts' idilhts'iy	'we're sitting'
ts' iyilh'is	'we're sneezing'
yets'ilhdic	'we're talking'
tëts'il'ën	'we're pitiful (poor us)'
nits'ilc'ëkh	'we're storming around, having a tantrum'
hats'ëltal	'we burst out laughing'
nits'ibī	'we're swimming around'
'its'ilekh	'we're doing it, making it'

When **ts'**- is followed by a vowel other than **i**, a vowel change may occur:

ï → e

ts' e ^h lcot	'we took it, we're taking it'
cf. ï clhcot	'I took it, I'm taking it'

ï → ë

ts' ë'ën	'we see him/her/it'
cf. ï s'ën	'I see him/her/it'

u → o

ts' **o**zĩ 'we're calling his/her name'

cf. **u**szĩ 'I'm calling his/her name'

ts' **o**ntan 'we're holding it'

cf. **y**untan 'he/she is holding him/her/it'

'They' (Third person plural, 3pl)

The basic form of 'they' (3pl subject) is **h-**, as seen above in 'they're coughing', **hidilkwis**. However, the basic form **h-** mainly only occurs when this prefix is the leftmost prefix in the verb. Some additional examples are as follows:

hilhk'agh 'they're fat'

hinilgit 'they're afraid'

hidĩlhts'iy 'they're sitting'

hiyilh'is 'they're sneezing'

After a consonant, **h** is optionally deleted:

hibighin**h**izdĩl ~ hibighinizdĩl 'they invited them'

nicin**h**idildĩlh ~ nicinidildĩlh 'they're walking around singing'

The same vowel changes observed with vowels after **ts'**- 'we' are found with vowels following **h-** 'they':

ĩ → e

t'alh **h**elhcot 'they took some food'

cf. **h**iyĩlhcot 'they took it'

ĩ → ë

hida **h**ë'ën 'they see a moose'

cf. **h**iyë'ën 'they see it'

u → o

ts'akë **ho**zī 'they're calling a woman's name'

cf. **hiy**uzī 'they're calling his/her name'

The prefix **h** marking 3pl subject is deleted between vowels when the second vowel is a vowel other than **i**. Thus sometimes a vowel change is the only marker of the third person plural subject. Compare the following:

hoendīl 'they left, went forth' (< ho-**h**-endīl)

cf. hosye 'I left, went forth'

cf. hots'endīl 'we left, went forth'

hots **ha**enzit 'they (du.) came from there (clan)' (< ha-**h**-enzit)

cf. hots hats'enzit 'we (du.) came from there (clan)'

cf. hots haszit 'I came from there (clan)'

Between two vowels, when the following vowel is expected to be **i**, the prefix **h** is not used. Instead, the preceding vowel is lengthened:

yeelhdic 'they're talking'

cf. yets'**i**lhdic 'we're talking'

tēēl'ën 'they're pitiful (poor them)'

cf. tēts'**i**l'ën 'we are pitiful'

Remember that in two syllable or longer words, stress tends to fall on the leftmost vowel other than **i** (**dede** 'sickness' vs. **c'ide** 'anciently'). But when an extra long vowel is somewhere in the word, the syllable containing the extra long vowel tends to get the main stress (rather than on the leftmost vowel other than **i**):

dilh neyeldic 'he/she is talking to him/herself'

dilh ney**ee**ldic 'they're talking to themselves'

(Listening for the location of main stress can thus help determine whether a form has a 3sg or 3pl subject.)

When **h-** occurs between two vowels, and the preceding vowel is **i**, that vowel changes to **aa** as a marker of the 3pl subject:

naalc'ëkh < ni-h-ilc'ëkh

'they're storming around, having a tantrum'

cf. nits'ilc'ëkh

'we're storming around, having a tantrum'

'aat'ah

'they're working'

cf. 'its'it'ah

'we're working'

When the third person plural prefix is the only prefix to a verb, then its shape varies between **hi~haa**:

haatsagh~hitsagh

'they're crying'

cf. ts'itsagh

'we're crying'

hitsagh

'he/she is crying'

Writing practice

The following words will be dictated to you. Write what you hear, keeping the above rules for spelling inner and outer subject prefixes in mind.

'we're eating it'

'they're eating it'

'he/she is eating it'

_____ or _____

'we became'

'he/she became'

_____ or _____

'they became'

'he/she is walking around'

'we're walking around'

'they're walking around'

'we bit him/her/it'

'he/she bit him/her/it'

'they bit him/her/it'

'we (pl.) bundled it'

'he/she bundled it'

'they bundled it'

'we're looking at a bear'

'they're looking at a bear'

'he/she is looking at a bear'

'they split up, got divorced'

'we split up, got divorced'

'they fired him/her'

'we fired him/her'

Verb paradigms inflected for subject

Having reviewed the inner and outer subject prefixes, we are now in a position to practice recognizing and writing the seven different subjects of some verbs, parallel to the seven different imperfective forms of 'cough'.

Practice recognizing subjects

Here are a few more examples of imperfective paradigms. As we go through these, you should underline, circle or highlight in some way the subject prefix in each verb.

Example:

digilkwis	'I'm coughing'
dilkwis	'cough, you're coughing'
diwhlhkwis	'cough (you pl.), you (pl.) are coughing'
didilkwis	'we (du.) are coughing'
ts'idilkwis	'we're coughing'
hidilkwis	'they're coughing'
dilkwis	'he/she is coughing'

Answer:

dilkwis	'he/she is coughing'
digilkwis	'I'm coughing'
dilkwis	'cough, you're coughing'
diwhlhkwis	'cough (you pl.), you (pl.) are coughing'
didilkwis	'we (du.) are coughing'
ts'idilkwis	'we're coughing'
hidilkwis	'they're coughing'

k'ënewist'ayh	'I'm blaming myself'
k'ëneont'ayh	'you're blaming yourself'
k'ënewit'ayh	'he/she is blaming him/herself'
k'ënewdit'ayh	'we (du.) are blaming ourselves'
k'ënets'iwit'ayh	'we're blaming ourselves'
k'ënewiht'ayh	'you (pl.) are blaming yourselves'
k'ëneewit'ayh	'they're blaming themselves'
so' 'igilco	'it's big enough for me, it fits me'
so' 'elco	'it's big enough for you, it fits you'
so' 'ilco	'it's big enough for him/her, it fits him/her'
so' 'idilco	'it's big enough for us (du.), it fits us (du.)'
so' 'its'ilco	'it's big enough for us, it fits us'
so' 'iwhlhco	'it's big enough for you (pl.), it fits you (pl.)'
so' 'aalco	'it's big enough for them, it fits them'
yecldic	'I'm talking'
yelhdic	'you're talking'
yelhdic	'he/she is talking'
yedildic	'we (du.) are talking'
yets'ilhdic	'we're talking'
yewhlhdic	'you (pl.) are talking'
yeelhdic	'they're talking'

lha'disgegh	'I'm finished'
lha'dingegh	'you're finished'
lha'digegh	'he/she is finished'
lha'diditgegh	'we (du.) are finished'
lha'izdigegh	'we're finished'
lha'diwhgegh	'you (pl.) are finished'
lha'aadigegh	'they're finished'
nigilgit	'I'm scared'
nīlgit	'you're scared'
nilgit	'he/she is scared'
nidilgit	'we (du.) are scared'
ts'inilgit	'we're scared'
niwhllhgit	'you (pl.) are scared'
hinilgit	'they're scared'
we'dust'ën'	'let me start'
we'dunt'ën'	'you can start, will start'
we'dut'ën'	'let him/her start, he/she can start, will start'
we'dudit'ën'	'let us (du.) start'
we'izdut'ën'	'let's start'
we'duht'ën'	'you (pl.) can start, will start'
we'aadut'ën'	'let them start, they can start, will start'

Practice writing subjects

Now you form and write the remaining forms of the paradigm from the two that are provided:

wenigilgit

weenilgit

to taditnelh

to ts'itatnelh

sis ɨdit'ën

sis ts'ë'ën

'I'm scared of it (situation)'

'you're scared of it (situation)'

'he/she is scared of it (situation)'

'we (du.) are scared of it (situation)'

'we're scared of it (situation)'

'you (pl.) are scared of it (situation)'

'they're scared of it (situation)'

'I'm going to drink some water.'

'You're going to drink some water.'

'He/she is going to drink some water.'

'We (du.) are going to drink some water.'

'We're going to drink some water.'

'You (pl.) are going to drink some water.'

'They're going to drink some water.'

'I see a bear'

'you see a bear'

'he/she see a bear'

'we (du.) see a bear'

'we see a bear'

'you (pl.) see a bear'

'they see a bear'